

switch off your PC from the mains for about 30 seconds before starting again. This, however, is quickly fixed with a kernel update.

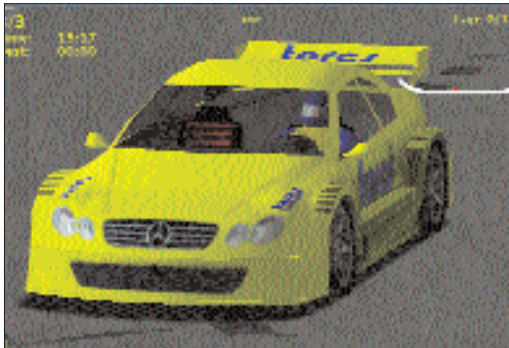
For newbies, we recommend Ubuntu 6.06 (Dapper Drake)—the graphical installation is simple and blindingly fast using the live CD, and nearly all your hardware will be supported—either through drivers supplied by the manufacturers or thanks to some well-written generic drivers.

For a more satisfying geek experience, not to mention a marked performance edge, you could try Gentoo. Take a weekend off, though—the build-everything-from-source approach is going to keep you busy for hours, and one false move means starting all over again. We've even seen reports of it taking 19 hours, which, at first, made us rather suspicious of our own time of nine hours. Next step: procuring all those 64-bit applications that will get the most out of your PC—all freeware or open source.

TORCS—The Open Car Racing Simulator

<http://torcs.sourceforge.net/>

While it passes itself off as a fun game, TORCS is also a platform for developers to test their abilities at writing intelligent robots they can pit against each other in a race. Porting it to 64-bit Linux means the AI calculations are going to be



faster, and as people start making more complex robots, we're going to see huge performance differences between the 32- and 64-bit versions.

Blender

www.blender.org

This extremely popular (and quite painful to learn) open source application is capable of creating some really enticing 3D graphics in the right hands, and a faster 64-bit edition means your creativity is going to take fruit sooner. Blender is available for both Linux and Windows.

Cinelerra

<http://heroinewarrior.com/cinelerra.php3>

Cinelerra is a very powerful Linux application for video capture, compositing and editing. It's one of very few applications that have been specifically written to take advantage of 64-bit CPUs, rather than just being ported from an old 32-bit version—in fact, you're probably going to encounter serious performance hits if you run the 32-bit code—loading uncompressed video into system memory isn't for the weak-processed. It will run on an

Athlon64, but what's recommended is a dual-core Opteron system. No, that wasn't a typo.

POV-Ray

www.povray.org

The Persistence Of Vision Raytracer is a 3D ray-tracing package that lets you create some incredibly photo-realistic scenes. What's unique and



challenging here is that you're going to write code that will eventually be translated into a 3D scene. You can get this for Windows as well.

And now, on to free stuff for Windows x64.

VirtualDub

www.virtualdub.org

You can now encode your videos from one format to the other with greater speed and the ability to load even more of your movie into the system's memory, taking away random skips while your hard drive is being read.

avast! Home Edition for Windows x64

www.avast.com

Our favourite free anti-virus just went 64-bit. Actually, avast! for XP x64 is a mix of both 64-bit and 32-bit code—this just to provide you with the added protection against 32-bit viruses.

Windows Defender

www.microsoft.com

Now in its second Beta, Windows Defender is a better "block spyware trying to come in" than a "clean up spyware that's already there" tool. And it's free. And it's 64-bit!

7Zip

www.7-zip.org

Another category of software that benefits from going 64-bit is compression. 7Zip is an open source compression program that packs files into the ZIP, GZIP, BZIP2 and TAR formats, and can unpack files from nearly all popular formats.

Should I, Shouldn't I

All isn't hunky-dory in the world of 64-bit software. For example, you'd expect a full 64-bit version of OpenOffice.org, but there isn't one—even the version that comes installed with 64-bit distributions is a combination of both. There also aren't 64-bit versions of much-needed programs such as Opera and Flash Player.

If you've been wondering whether you should shift to a 64-bit OS, you should—soon after making sure that all your hardware is supported—especially hardware like your old printer. Eventually, you're not going to have a choice anyway. So welcome to the new world! (Don't bonk your head on your way in.) ■

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